pushing forward against the English-held lands, scored victory after victory. In July of 1189, so ill that he had to be supported by two of his knights in order to stay on his horse, Henry II agreed to meet the two rebels and yield to their demands. These had expanded: Henry was now required to give up any claim to the allegiance of all English knights who had gone over to Richard's side.*

Almost unable to stand, Henry took the required oaths and then came forward to give Richard the customary kiss of peace. Gerald de Barri, Henry's royal clerk and chaplain, records that as the king kissed the air beside Richard's ear, he whispered, "God grant that I may not die until I have had my revenge on you."[4]

Back at his headquarters in the castle of Chinon, Henry received the list of knights who had deserted his cause for Richard's. At the head of the list was his son John. Until that moment, says Roger of Hoveden, Henry had not known that his favored son had crossed over to the enemy. "Surprised at this beyond measure," Roger of Hoveden concludes, "[he] cursed the day on which he was born." He had already lost the ability to stand. On his deathbed, he made his last confession; and on July 6, 1189, Henry II died in the thirty-fifth year of his reign.[5]

Richard claimed the English throne. He was now thirty-one, an experienced soldier and politician, dazzling in person: nicknamed "Lionheart" by his soldiers, tall, golden-haired, "of a shapely build" with "straight and flexible limbs," possessing the valor of Hector, the greatness of Alexander, and the manhood of Roland (at least according to the anonymous starstruck author of the *Itinerarium Regis Ricardi*). He released his mother Eleanor from her long house arrest and then, immediately after, announced that he would fulfill his father's undone vows by going on crusade.[6]

Crusades were expensive. Richard ransacked the treasury, sold state offices to the highest bidder, and collected 10 percent of the kingdom's goods and cash as a "tithe Saladin" (a "violent extortion," says Roger of Wendover, "which veiled the vice of rapacity under the name of charity"). On August 16, 1190, Richard and Philip—having sworn an oath to divide all proceeds from their conquests equally between them—departed from Marseille, bound for Jerusalem.[7]

BY THEN, Frederick Barbarossa was dead.

He had left Germany in April 1189, sailing along the Danube to Vienna, and then traveling along the long difficult land route through the kingdom of Hungary (where he was joined by the king of Hungary's brother with some two thousand troops) and then over the rough terrain of Serbia and Bosnia.*